NOVELISTIC SCREENPLAY

POKÉMON NOCTURNE

EPISODE 04

The Price of Becoming a Young Prodigy

Author

Adelbert Vervloet

Working compilation

Status · draft · pass 1/3 recorded · EN-GB apparatus

Format	Novelistic screenplay · EN anchors
Target duration	To be set — corpus ≈ 100 min read aloud
Scenes	11
Version	2026-09-23 · EN-GB dossier after P1

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Episode sheet

Series Pokémon Nocturne

Episode 04 — The Price of Becoming a Young Prodigy

Author Adelbert Vervloet

Logline

In Ecruteak, Eusine names the living debt. Gold/Richter questions tradition; Oak turns the collective gaze aside. Kuni refuses the neutrality of art. Karin breaks the strong / weak adage. Night returns creatures without a trainer — modest level, ancient terror.

Place in the arc

Due: Johto as shelter (ep. 03); Lance–Rocket; Arbok on the screen; sibling camouflage.

Paid: questions to Eusine; Oak as counterpart; hunting crop; niveleur at 22–23.

Open: cry beyond the hall; Hoothoot; masterless creatures of the night.

Characters — this episode only

Name	Function here
Gold/Richter	Questions; unease at the debt; crop
Chris/Maria	Pen; confiding; Krise
Eusine / Morty	Address; Q&A; finitude
Oak	Turns the collective gaze; faith / science
Karin / Kuni	Debt as cage; art not neutral; adage The Kimono Girl who crossed paths with the protagonist during the Radio Tower raid
Krise / Bryan	Hoothoot; Jigglypuff

Places (EN anchors)

Ecruteak (hall, Tin Tower, streets) · festival · rooftops.

Technical notes — outside the scenes

Few notes in the manuscript. These leave the body.

Heading	Note
niveleur	Single spelling: niveleur (not leveller). Reading ≈ 22–23; Arbok one notch above.

hunting crop	One form only. Never whip.
Metalepsis	Do not write “end of episode 03” in the narrative. Goldenrod, on the screen.
Eusine	He / his throughout. Opening she/her in the DeepL draft is an error.
BGM	Traces = address only (EP S span). No christening. Don’t Listen to Her already at the League (ep. 02): deliberate reuse.

BGM index — pieces (OST)

Names born of circumstance, in Morris / Toy. Reused when the circumstance rhymes.

Scene	Piece	Span
The Living Debt	Little Boy Belmont	to be fixed
Science and Faith	Heavenly Father	01:09–01:50
Art is not neutral	Being Dracula’s Son	entry
Powerful Pokémon…	Part of the Same History	unify with ep. 01
Creatures of the night	Don’t Listen to Her	01:04–02:04
Creatures of the night	Powerful Predatory Deadly	02:14–02:18

BGM index — traces

Address only. No third column. Duration is the label.

Scene	BGM
Tradition Under Siege	EP03 S02 04:00–04:54
Tradition Under Siege	EP06 S01 10:00–10:37
Powerful Pokémon…	EP05 S02 18:21–18:59

Order of scenes

1. The Living Debt
2. Tradition Under Siege
3. Science and Faith
4. After the Science Show

5. Respecting Finitude

6. Falling in Love with You Again

7. Hoothoot's Aerial Watch

8. The Girls' Confiding

9. Art Is Not Neutral

10. Strong Pokémon. Weak Pokémon

11. The Appearance of the Creatures of the Night

The scenes are inserted here.

Scene – The Living Debt

The Ecruteak Conference Hall, Eusine's speech

BGM: 'Little Boy Belmont'

The Ecruteak conference hall was bathed in a heavy, golden light. Twilight streamed in through the tall windows, lengthening the shadows cast by the dark wooden pillars. The air smelled of old paper, cold incense and stone dust. On the podium, Eusine stood upright, his hands resting flat on the lectern. When his voice rose, it was deep, slow, almost sing-song.

'Johto has not always been as you see it today. Long ago, our lands were stifled. Fear closed off hearts like an invisible hand. We could no longer look up at the sky without trembling. Neighbours distrusted one another, for betrayal lurked everywhere — not just from outside, but as if it had been whispered into the hollow of every ear, turning bonds against themselves."

Gold/Richter stood motionless, but his fingers clenched tighter around his knees. He lowered his head slightly, as if the words weighed too heavily upon him. The solemn tone of the speech made him feel uneasy. He understood what was being said, but it seemed to him to belong to a world too vast, too distant. He had taken no notes. Just a short sentence, almost scribbled in the corner of his notebook: *'Don't forget.'*

Chris/Maria listened without moving. Her face was tense. She understood too, yet the language made her feel uneasy. She felt as though she were too small for this speech. Her fingers fidgeted distractedly with the hem of her sleeve. No notes from her either. Just a small, discreet cross in the margin of her notebook, as if to mark that she was there, present, but not at ease.

Eusine continued, her voice as measured as ever:

'Families lived in silence and submission. Children grew up unable to dream of a free future, for even hope seemed suspect, as if poisoned at its source. Freedom was now nothing more than a word that one no longer dared to utter aloud, for fear that it might be turned against one.'

Professor Oak, standing a little further back in the shadows, listened with perfect politeness. His eyebrows furrowed imperceptibly. The mythical, almost religious tone was unlike anything he had ever encountered. He jotted down just two words in his little notebook: *'Ho-oh / Lugia – living debt*'. He closed the notebook with an almost embarrassed gesture.

Karin, in her discreet corner, stood very straight. Her fingers were clenched on the edge of the chair. The speech weighed more heavily on her than on the others. She knew this philosophy all too well: the debt, the constant vigilance, the absolute refusal to fall back into darkness. She knew what it truly cost, and what it could break in those who submitted to it too strictly. She clenched her teeth and stared at a spot on the floor, as if to contain what was welling up inside her. She took no notes.

Eusine paused briefly, then continued in a more measured, solemn tone:

'Then… two beings descended from the sky. Ho-oh and Lugia. They did not come as distant, indifferent gods. They came because they still believed in us. They broke the chains that held us back. They drove away the shadows that weighed upon our souls and our lands.'

The Kimono Girls sat motionless, their hands resting on their knees. They listened as one might listen to an ancient song. Their faces were serene, almost at peace. Morty, his eyes half-closed, seemed almost in a trance. He did not move.

Gold/Richter felt his unease growing. The word ‘debt’ stuck in his throat. He shifted slightly in his chair, uncomfortable, then crossed his arms without realising it. He didn’t like what this speech seemed to be silently demanding of him.

Eusine concluded, his voice having grown deeper once more:

‘From that day onwards, we have carried their memory as a living debt. Every stone carved into our temples, every song we raise at dawn, every gesture of respect we pass on to our children… is our way of telling them: We have not forgotten. And we shall not betray the faith they placed in us. For what they gave us was not without cost. They believed in us when we had ceased to believe in ourselves. And that is why, even today, we take care never to fall back into the darkness we once knew.”

The silence that followed was long and heavy. Eusine lowered his head, as if exhausted by his own words.

Karin remained perfectly still, but her jaw was clenched. Her fingers, still clenched around the edge of the chair, were turning slightly white. She knew the price of this ‘living debt’. And she knew that, at times, this constant vigilance could become a cage just as suffocating as the one it was supposed to prevent.

Then, in the distance, a muffled, violent cry rang out — an animalistic howl mingled with human voices. The ground trembled ever so slightly. Something heavy had just crashed into an outer door.

The chaos had just begun.

End of scene

Scene – Tradition Under Siege

The Ecruteak conference hall. After Eusine’s address (Q&A)

Twilight was still streaming in through the tall windows, but it had grown heavier. The shadows of the pillars stretched slowly across the wooden floor. The air smelled of old paper, cold incense and fine dust. On the podium, Eusine took a sip of water. He set the glass down with a slightly sluggish gesture, as if he had already spoken too much. He looked up at the assembly.

‘Welcome. I warmly welcome your questions.’

Several hands went up. Eusine answered the first few courteously, but a certain weariness was already evident in his demeanour. His shoulders were slightly slumped, his gaze a little more distant. He had spoken at length earlier, and the shift to more direct exchanges seemed to require some effort on his part.

Gold/Richter waited patiently. He hadn’t raised his hand straight away. He surveyed the room, waiting. He had a vague sense that his questions were not quite of the same nature as the others,

and he preferred not to ask them too soon. When he judged that Eusine was a little less pressed for time, he raised his hand, without insistence.

It took Eusine a second too long to notice him.

“I would be delighted.”

Gold/Richter rose slightly to take the microphone. When he spoke, his voice was clear, yet a little low, as if he were still hesitating.

“Thank you for the welcome… Could you compare Johto’s traditions with those of other regions? The advantages, or disadvantages, if you’ve ever stayed elsewhere?”

Eusine paused ever so briefly. The word ‘stayed’ seemed to have struck a chord with him. Nevertheless, he replied:

“Certainly. Empirically speaking, Johto’s tradition stands out for its traditional precocity. At least, compared to the regions where I’ve stayed, Johto stands out as a pioneer. Freedom isn’t as accessible there as it is here. That cultural legacy isn’t so deeply rooted. It’s not something we can take for granted.”

Gold/Richter lowered his gaze slightly. The word ‘traditional precocity’ had left a bitter taste in his mouth.

After a brief silence, he continued:

“...Your account gives the impression that Johto is a utopia. We tend to idealise it.”

BGM ‘EP03 S02 04:00 04:54’

A slight stir rippled through the room. A few people imperceptibly straightened their backs. A discreet exchange of glances passed between two of the Kimono Girls. It was not hostile, yet Gold/Richter sensed that something had changed. The attention seemed to have tightened slightly around him.

Eusine shook his head slowly.

“No. Johto isn’t flawless… But what we’ve achieved, even if it’s only partial, didn’t come for free. It comes at the price paid by those who came before us.”

He paused, then continued in a slightly lower voice:

“Johto has brought certain things: a form of decentralisation, a more artisanal rigour, and a reduction in rigid hierarchies. The most despotic forms have receded. The air we breathe there has an ordinary smell, but it remains free. And that is no small thing.”

One of the Kimono Girls then spoke up, without raising her voice:

“Our trade is hereditary… but not our status, nor our title.”

Another followed, more simply:

“We are not an aristocracy. We are content simply to blend in with the locals. Remaining craftswomen, even if it is a cultural tradition.”

Gold/Richter turned his head slightly. He recognised the woman who had just spoken. He’d already come across her in Azalea Town. Their eyes met for a fraction of a second. She looked away first.

Gold/Richter turned back to Eusine.

“All right. Let us return to my questions… What challenges is tradition currently facing?”

Eusine looked at him a little longer this time. He did not answer straight away.

“For example…?”

Gold/Richter lowered his voice slightly:

“…These days, people pray less. Young people visit the ancient sites less often. They seem to be gradually becoming less attached to them.”

Eusine held his gaze for a moment, then replied without trying to sugar-coat it:

“Yes. Not in any dramatic way. It’s more subtle. The elders pass away, the younger ones move on elsewhere, and no one really notices that something is missing. Until the day we realise there’s no one left to pass on what really mattered. And by then, we can’t even put a name to what’s been lost.”

A silence, slightly longer than the previous ones, settled over the room. Gold/Richter could feel it. He had the impression that the attention around him had grown even more intense. It was not hostility, nor even outright judgment. It was more diffuse, harder to put into words. As if the very fact of being watched made the air a little thicker to breathe. He felt strangely exposed, even though no one had actually raised their voice.

He knew he might have been better off stopping there. He didn’t stop.

‘Thank you for your answer,’ he said. ‘One last question… What stance should we take towards traditional values today? Should we stick to them come what may?’

Eusine frowned ever so slightly.

‘…Do you mean we should give them up?’

Gold/Richter shook his head, a little too quickly.

BGM “**EP06 S01 10:00–10:37”**

“No, that’s not it. I mean… in the past, we could follow these values without too many problems. But today, the same principles, the same expectations… they pose more difficulties. Shouldn’t we adapt them, in some way?”

This time, the silence that followed was more pronounced. Very quiet conversations began to break out in several rows. Not hostile murmurs. Rather, questions being exchanged in hushed tones. Gold/Richter had the impression that the air had grown even a little thinner. The atmosphere had become heavier, more oppressive. He didn’t know exactly what was being said, but he suspected he was the subject of it. It wasn’t anger. It was more diffuse, harder to bear.

Seated beside him, Chris/Maria gripped her pen more tightly than was seemly. Unbeknownst to her, her fingers trembled slightly. The pen slipped from her grasp and fell to the floor with a soft thud.

Gold/Richter bent down immediately. He picked it up and handed it to her. As she took it back, their fingers brushed against each other.

He pulled his hand away as if he had burnt himself.

It was a very restrained movement, almost imperceptible to most people. But Eusine, who had been watching them for a while, saw it clearly. His gaze lingered on them for a second. He said nothing. He simply understood that there had been something between them, and that this something had been interrupted. In his eyes was a kind of sad and cautious recognition.

Gold/Richter bowed his head for a moment, then looked up at Eusine.

“My apologies… if we could leave that subject aside. My final question: why didn’t Johto escape the darkness you spoke of in your speech? Was something brewing back then?”

Eusine opened his mouth. He was about to reply. One could already sense that the answer would be a darker one.

It was then that a man’s voice, coming from the back rows, rang out with a sort of light-hearted bonhomie:

“Oh, my journey has been well worth it. What a rare delight! A young man already indignant at the state of his generation…”

All eyes turned to Professor Oak. He was sitting slightly set back, his hands clasped on his lap, with a smile that was neither mocking nor particularly warm. Just there.

Eusine fell silent. He lowered his head slightly, as if relieved to have been interrupted.

Gold/Richter said nothing more.

End of scene

Scene – Science and Faith

The Ecruteak lecture theatre. After Oak’s speech

BGM ‘Heavenly Father’ 01:09–01:50

The twilight had faded a little further. The air in the hall seemed less heavy than a moment earlier, but the tension had not completely dissipated. A few hushed conversations lingered amongst the rows, as if no one really dared to break the taut silence.

Professor Oak had stepped slightly into the light. He spoke in a measured voice, with a certain deliberate expansiveness, like someone who first takes in the dimensions of the room before stepping fully into it.

‘Unexpected spectacles are usually more valuable than planned programmes, aren’t they?’ he said, slowly sweeping his gaze across the room. He did not linger on any one face in particular. ‘I wish the young people in Kanto would sometimes be a little more alert, as this young man was just now. Otherwise, life would become rather dull, and so would our own thoughts.’

Gold/Richter felt his shoulders tense. He lowered his gaze slightly, his hands resting on his thighs. For a second, he thought Oak was going to single him out. But the professor carried on without pausing, and the room’s attention, rather than focusing on him, seemed to drift slightly. As if Oak had

deliberately drawn out his sentences to prevent the collective gaze from lingering too long on any one person.

Eusine, from the podium, watched the scene in silence. He tilted his head ever so slightly, an almost imperceptible movement. He had understood.

‘I hope I haven’t stolen too much of the limelight from your speech, Mr Chairman …?’ added Oak with a hint of gentle irony. But in the way he phrased the question, there was a sense of discreet control, as if he were still gauging the atmosphere before continuing.

Eusine replied after a brief silence:

“…No. Not at all. It gives us a slightly different perspective. But to what do we owe the pleasure of your presence in Johto?”

Oak shrugged slightly. There was a calculated ease about the gesture.

“If you care so much about your region, why doesn’t it attract more outsiders? And why should someone like me limit their interests so strictly?”

Eusine did not pick up on the remark. He merely replied in a calm voice:

“I’ve already had the chance to meet people from outside… So much the better. I’m not one to cling to honours. Go ahead, if you wish.”

Gold/Richter felt something relax ever so slightly in the nape of his neck. He hadn’t been singled out. Oak hadn’t pointed the finger at him. Nevertheless, he kept his hands on his thighs, his fingers still a little stiff, but he was able to raise his eyes a little higher.

Morty then spoke, in a calm voice:

“That does raise a question, though… We know the strength of our traditional heritage. But the Gym Leaders, even those who take an interest in it — like Pryce or Claire — aren’t usually available during the day. You, on the other hand, are here. Am I to conclude that scientists have more freedom than we do? If I’m not overstepping the mark.”

Oak slumped into an empty chair with a somewhat old-fashioned ease. He crossed his legs slowly, as if taking his time to choose his posture.

“Scientists don’t just need holidays,” he replied. “They need some more breathable air from time to time. Especially when that air comes from Johto.” He cast a sidelong glance at Eusine. “And when the answers you get there are a little less conventional than elsewhere.”

A brief silence followed. Then Oak added, with a half-smile:

“Congratulations, in any case. Your audience was attentive.”

Eusine was not immediately sure whether it was a compliment or a tease. He did not bother to find out. He simply lowered his eyes slightly towards the lectern, a discreet gesture.

Chris/Maria, standing a little further away, asked in a slightly hesitant voice:

“So… status isn’t that important to you?”

Gold/Richter tensed imperceptibly. He would have preferred her not to speak. But Oak replied without raising his voice, almost as if he were addressing her alone:

“Not obsessively. But I haven’t given it up entirely either. Status is neutral in itself. It’s how you use it that matters. You can use it in a healthy way… or not. And I must admit that temptation has sometimes crossed my mind, too. Unfortunately.”

He paused, then continued in a slightly lower voice:

“In Kanto, I’m often treated as someone untouchable. Almost untouchable. Here in Johto, I’m more often treated as a mere colleague. A craftsman amongst others, even if it’s in the field of science. And I must say I prefer it that way.”

One of the Kimono Girls, standing a little further away, murmured to herself, loud enough to be heard:

“So Kanto doesn’t really suit you…”

Oak turned his head slightly in her direction without staring at her. There was a very brief silence — barely a fraction of a second — before he replied. His gaze shifted slightly, as if he were taking half a second longer to choose his words.

There was a kind of old-fashioned gentleness in that movement: he was answering, but without allowing the assembly’s gaze to linger too long on any one spot.

“Yes, enough. But I think Kanto needs to be a bit more open. To find other driving forces. Not just the ones it’s always known.”

His tone was measured, almost light-hearted. But Gold/Richter had the fleeting impression that Oak was holding something back. It wasn’t apparent in his words, but in that very brief moment of hesitation, in the way he had looked away slightly before replying. As if he’d chosen not to say everything he was thinking.

Another silence fell, a more pensive one. Gold/Richter noticed that the hushed conversations were resuming a little more naturally in some of the ranks. The atmosphere seemed a little less heavy than it had been a moment earlier.

Morty spoke again, with a certain reserve:

‘…One last question, if I may. Why do scientists sometimes join this sort of gathering? With us?’

Oak looked ahead for a moment before replying. This time, the silence was longer, more personal.

“It’s an old story. And I’ve told it many times before. But few people really remember it.” He shrugged slightly. “Many people see me more as a man of faith than as a man of reason. An abbot, sometimes. A bishop, even. It reassures them, or it annoys them. I don’t know.”

From the back of the room, a woman’s voice rang out, calm and clear:

“It’s true. I’ve often been told that Professor Oak seems more like a priest than a scientist,” Karin confirmed.

Oak turned his head towards her. He recognised her. A very faint smile flitted across his face, almost nostalgic, but it did not linger. He looked away slightly, as if to prevent attention from lingering too long in her direction. Gold/Richter noticed the gesture. He wasn’t quite sure why, but he sensed that something important had just happened.

Oak spoke again, his voice a little deeper:

‘When I was younger, I was often treated like a hero. And for a time, I believed that feelings were enough. That passion and willpower could carry us through anything. Until the day I realised that neither feelings nor reason alone are enough. You need both. To maintain a certain balance between humans, Pokémon and the world around us. That is why I turned to science. Not because I rejected the rest. But because I thought someone had to fill that role with clear-headedness.”

He paused for a moment. His fingers, resting on his knee, tightened slightly.

“One of my students understood this better than I did, in some respects.”

Gold/Richter lowered his gaze. He didn’t need to be told who he was talking about. He felt his shoulders slump a little further.

Oak sat up slightly in his chair and changed his tone, as if to lighten the atmosphere:

“But I think I’ve been talking a bit too much. My colleague, Dr Fuji, will no doubt be better placed to explain the precise reason for our visit.”

BGM “EP04 S02 20:40–22:00”

Dr Fuji nodded slowly.

“Thank you, Oak.” He paused briefly. “We haven’t come here just for fun. We’ve also come to collect certain samples. For my future research.”

A faint murmur of doubt rippled through the room. Fuji did not seem to take offence.

‘Your mistrust is understandable,’ he said in a calm voice. “Many believe that faith and science are two separate realms. I myself long held a similar view. But the further one advances in science, the more one realises that it rests on something else. On a kind of drive, or faith. Without that, it quickly becomes dangerous. It needs direction. And that direction does not come of its own accord.”

He lowered his voice slightly.

“Those who have understood this have often paid dearly for it. Or have come close to paying the price. That is why I cannot blame you for not yet seeing it clearly. Science is a tool. But it is not a compass.”

BGM “EP06 S01 10:00 10:37” 00:22–end

A different kind of silence settled over the room. Heavier, but not hostile. Gold/Richter noticed that hushed conversations were resuming a little more naturally in certain corners of the room. The atmosphere seemed a little less stifling. Not light yet, but it weighed less heavily on his shoulders.

Eusine then spoke, in a measured voice:

‘Before we go our separate ways… would you mind signing a few autographs, Professor? For those who’d like one.’

Oak hesitated for a second. He cast a quick glance at Gold/Richter—so quick that almost no one noticed—then looked away.

“That might make me seem a bit too important… And I haven’t come here on a diplomatic mission. I don’t represent Kanto.”

Eusine pressed gently:

“What if it were simply a gesture of courtesy?”

Oak looked at him for a moment, then shrugged slightly with a faint, weary smile.

“…All right. But on one condition: that you sign too, Mr Chairman.”
There was a sense of deliberate balance in this request, as if he refused to place himself solely in the position of the giver and preferred to create an exchange, however symbolic.

Eusine did not seem surprised. He nodded slightly.

“…Agreed.”

End of scene

Scene – After the science show

The conference hall in Ecruteak. After Oak’s show

Night had already well and truly fallen over Ecruteak when Gold/Richter and Chris/Maria left the building. The air was cool, heavy with the scent of damp wood and fallen leaves. In the cloakroom, Gold/Richter had unhurriedly collected his riding crop, walking stick and overcoat, returning the name tag with a precise gesture. Chris/Maria had done the same with her belongings. They had not exchanged many words.

Outside, some twenty metres away, Professor Oak and Dr Fuji were walking side by side on the pavement. They were wearing dark overcoats, plain enough not to attract attention. Oak walked with measured steps, slightly stooped, his hands in his pockets. Fuji, standing straighter, kept his eyes fixed on the ground, as if he were still thinking about something.

Gold/Richter spotted them first. He didn’t speed up straight away. He watched for a moment, then set off at a steady pace, with Chris/Maria by his side. They caught up with the two men without running.

‘Good evening, Professor,’ said Gold/Richter. His voice was loud enough to be heard, but not too loud.

BGM “EP01S02 15:12–15:54”

Oak and Fuji turned round. Oak turned his head with an almost calculated slowness. His gaze fell on Gold/Richter, then on Chris/Maria. There was neither coldness nor genuine kindness in that gaze; only a kind of discreet, almost automatic assessment. Gold/Richter felt something tighten slightly in his chest. It was not mistrust, but a sense of being **seen** more deeply than he would have wished.

Oak then smiled, a small, somewhat weary smile.

‘We’d like to invite you to have a cup of tea or coffee, if you’d like,’ he said. His voice was soft, almost pastoral, with a touch of old-fashioned eccentricity.

Gold/Richter nodded in agreement. He didn’t really have a choice, and he knew it.

Traditional café

They settled into a small, traditional café two streets away. The place was quiet, neither empty nor crowded. A few customers seated at tables were speaking in hushed tones. The lighting was warm, slightly yellow, and the dark wooden tables bore signs of wear. The scent of tea and pastries mingled with that of old wood.

Oak and Fuji ordered decaffeinated tea and a few simple pastries. Gold/Richter and Chris/Maria had black tea and several cakes. For a while, nobody really spoke. All that could be heard was the clinking of spoons against cups and, now and then, a quiet laugh from a neighbouring table.

Gold/Richter turned his head slightly towards the window. Outside, the street was almost deserted. His shoulders were slightly hunched, his hands resting motionless on his thighs. He did not seem tired in the usual sense of the word; it was a more long-standing, deeply ingrained weariness.

It was he who broke the silence, after letting a moment pass.

'Thank you, Professor… for getting me out of that awkward situation earlier.'

His voice was low, a little hesitant.

Oak took a small sip of tea before replying. He set his cup down carefully.

"You owe me nothing," he said. "It is I who am indebted to you. You've given me a rare opportunity to improvise, to play around a bit… and to bridge the gap with ordinary people. It's something I do far too rarely. That sort of pleasure isn't to be found in laboratories."

There was a somewhat old-fashioned, almost affected, yet sincere lightness in his voice. He looked at Gold/Richter for a moment longer, then added, more softly:

'That said… you should take care not to ask questions that are too pointed, young man. In certain places, appearing too clever at your age isn't always to your advantage.'

Gold/Richter did not reply. He lowered his gaze slightly towards his cup. Chris/Maria, sitting next to him, turned her head towards Oak with a slight, wry smile.

Chris/Maria spoke again, in a lighter tone:

"Besides, — Gold/Richter is more of a bureaucrat than a Pokédex holder, you know. He writes such meticulous reports that even Professor Elm gets worried sometimes… It's handy for research, but it's a bit of a burden for someone his age."

Oak let out a quiet chuckle, almost as if taken aback.

'A bureaucrat?' he repeated. 'That's unprecedented.'

Oak watched them for a moment without speaking. There was a slightly eccentric, almost pastoral gentleness in his gaze, but also a hint of caution. He did not know them as well as Elm did, and it showed in the way he looked at them: with interest, but without familiarity.

Gold/Richter kept his eyes downcast. He seemed both embarrassed and resigned.

"I just need a bit more support from the older generation than others do," he said at last, in a low voice. "For goodness' sake, please… I can't adapt to all this at once."

Oak looked at him for a long moment without replying straight away. Then he nodded slowly.

“Ah. That’s why the elderly are not merely a bunch of wrecks,” he said. “Their life experiences can sometimes be of use to young people, at some point.”

There was a kind of residual, almost automatic kindness in his voice, though it was not without sincerity.

Chris/Maria regarded him with a touch of ironic curiosity.

“With all due respect, Professor… were you discussing science in pastoral terms?”

Oak smiled slightly, without taking offence.

“It’s a non-scientific hangover from my past,” he said. “It has nothing to do with science itself. It’s simply my way of humanising what I do. As one gets older, one sometimes needs these little tricks.”

He paused, then added, more soberly:

“I’m sorry I wasn’t there for your graduation ceremony. When you were given your Pokédexes. I wasn’t free to travel to Johto at the time. Nor was I available for certain radio programmes. At the very least, I could have brought you some small gifts.”

Chris/Maria shook her head gently.

“Don’t worry about it. We’re teenagers, but we’re not really children who need that sort of thing.”

Oak nodded, without pressing the matter.

He then turned to Chris/Maria.

“Then you begin, if you will. How do you find the task of catching them?”

BGM “EP01 S01 14:37–16:34”

Chris/Maria fell silent for a moment; she twirled her cup slightly between her fingers.

“This task confronts me with more ethical and moral questions than I’d have thought,” she said at last. “I do catch Pokémon, but neither excessively nor indiscriminately. Novice Trainers catch anything that moves. To me, that is a form of decadence. At that rate, the ecosystem would quickly deteriorate. So I only catch Pokémon that seem willing to get to know us… or those that pose a real threat to humans.”

Oak listened to her without interruption, and in his eyes there was a hint of quiet respect.

“Commendable,” he said simply. “And what developments have you made in this field?”

Chris/Maria shrugged slightly.

“A closeness to and respect for nature, I suppose. My ability to observe more subtle emotions has improved. But it’s not a deductive skill like that of the lad here.”

She cast a quick, almost conspiratorial glance at Gold/Richter.

Gold/Richter did not look up straight away. He seemed lost in thought, his fingers clenched around his lukewarm cup.
Chris/Maria let a brief silence pass, then continued in a slightly sharper, almost ironic tone:

“Gold/Richter and I are filling in the gaps in your data. But let’s face it, it’s handy… Sending kids our age rather than adults. It’s cheaper, I suppose.”

She had not raised her voice, yet a distinct edge lingered in her remark.
She paused briefly, then added, more softly:

“It weighs on me a bit to see him carrying such a burden. Ever since he was a little boy.”

She had not meant to provoke Oak; she had merely spoken her mind, for that evening he was one of the few to whom she could voice such thoughts without them seeming futile.

Oak remained silent for a moment. He looked down at the table, as if weighing up the truth of her remark.
“…It’s a question I’ve asked myself too, back in the day. But as time goes by, you end up seeing things differently.”

Oak did not reply straight away. He remained silent for a moment, his gaze fixed on the table. Then, slowly, he took a Poké Ball from his pocket and placed it in front of him. He tossed it gently without a word. A Skarmory appeared, already calm, but strangely distant, as if it were not really there.

“You can check its level, if you’d like,” said Oak.

Gold/Richter removed his cuff without a word and checked his leveller. He stared at the screen for a long moment. The level displayed was strangely low, given the Professor’s reputation.

“Why is its level…?” he asked at last, in a low voice. “Where are your former partners?”

He stroked one of the Skarmory’s feathers with a slow, almost absent-minded gesture. Oak returned the Skarmory to its Poké Ball with a calm movement. He caught the ball with precision.

“Retired,” he replied. “A high level doesn’t exempt them from the effects of ageing. I don’t have much time left to train today’s Pokémon… or the young ones.”

He paused. His gaze drifted for a moment towards the window.

“Young Pokémon are becoming increasingly difficult to guide,” he finally said. “Not just because they’re wilder. It’s the distance. With humans, we can still find common ground, even when the generations are far apart. With Pokémon, especially the younger ones, that distance is greater. We no longer share the same culture, the same way of understanding one another.”

He paused briefly, slowly turning his cup between his hands.

“Pryce, Blaine and Agatha still manage it, but not without effort. It’s a kind of perseverance that I respect all the more because I no longer quite possess it myself. We need the younger generation, not to take advantage of them, but because their value is genuine.”

There was a kind of lucid, almost gentle weariness in his voice.
“All right. But at least be so kind as not to count on us to save the world.” Chris/Maria conceded.
Professor Oak was in awe of her tenacity.

Gold/Richter stowed his **leveller** in silence. His shoulders were slumped slightly more than at the start of the conversation.

Oak regarded him for a moment, then nodded towards the device.

“What an unusual device for you…”

“It’s a custom-made device by Professor Elm, at my request,” replied Gold/Richter. “An external Pokédex gadget used to check Pokémon levels.”

“Why don’t you just use the Pokédex directly?” asked Oak.

Gold/Richter fell silent for a moment.

BGM “EP04 S01 22:40 24:12”

“I’m following Red’s guidelines,” he said at last. “Not to use it, so as to develop our intuition. But when facing trickier enemies, we sometimes find out their levels for safety’s sake. Besides… I wouldn’t want to give away my identity as a Pokédex holder. According to the stories, Red was identified by Team Rocket.”

Oak looked at him for a long time. There was a kind of gentle, almost affectionate irony in his eyes, but also something more sombre.

“Oh,” he said. “So you think you’re smarter than him?”

The question sounded like a tease, but also like a subtle test.

Gold/Richter sat up slightly, almost indignant.

“Not in the slightest! His era simply didn’t allow him to take that precaution.”

Oak nodded, without pressing the matter.

‘You know… your unconventional approach precedes you rather than your reputation,’ he said.

Gold/Richter looked up at him, surprised.

“What do you mean?”

Oak smiled slightly.

“First of all, you’ve sidelined your Pokémon partner. It’s simply too… ingenious.”

Chris/Maria then chimed in, in a lighter tone:

“Oh, speaking of which, I’m part of this dynamic too. I’ve sidelined mine as well. Since, when it comes to catching Pokémon, I don’t really know what this one’s for…”

Gold/Richter turned his head towards her, visibly relieved that she was taking some of the heat for that remark.

“I didn’t want to choose either one,” he said. “But I chose Cyndaquil anyway, because Totodile really put me off…”

Oak regarded him for a moment, then added in an almost neutral tone:

“Because you respect one of your predecessors who chose the Fire-type, and hate the other who chose the Water-type…?”

Gold/Richter remained silent. He did not deny it, yet neither did he confirm.

Oak did not press the matter further. He merely nodded, as if he had understood something without needing to hear any more.

Oak observed Gold/Richter for a moment, then spoke with measured, almost scientific candour:

“In this matter, I must rely on scientific objectivity: its effectiveness is not yet particularly striking.”

Gold/Richter lowered his eyes slightly. He did not look up straight away. When he replied, his voice was flat and uninflected:

'…Noted.'

The silence that followed lasted a little longer than necessary. Chris/Maria turned her head slightly towards him, without saying a word. She had noticed the change in tone.

Oak, sensing that he had touched on something more fragile than he had anticipated, added gently:

"I'm not saying this to discourage you. His future is still open and full of potential. Red was more talented than Green, despite his relative lack of resources. I have no reason to lie to you: you, too, can go far."

Gold/Richter kept his gaze fixed on his cup for a moment. His fingers remained resting on the rim of the porcelain, motionless. When he finally spoke, it was in a low, almost resigned voice:

"That is precisely where my concern lies."

He paused briefly, as if trying to put things into words without making them sound too heavy.

"We in Johto inherit the symbol. But not the full resources. We haven't had the same mentoring, nor the same access to data. And Johto isn't as combat-oriented as Kanto is. We risk being… overshadowed. What's more, I've never met Red. There's been no concrete handover. We have to reinvent everything from scratch."

He stopped there. He said nothing more. The silence that followed was uncomfortable.

Chris/Maria lowered her gaze slightly, her expression growing more serious. She had understood, without him needing to say so explicitly, part of what had been weighing on him for some time.

Gold/Richter continued, more softly, almost to himself:

"I only hope to be able to draw on the cultural legacy… Red's authentic approaches and principles. Rather than trying to match him directly."

He was not seeking sympathy; he was merely stating a fact, and in that statement lay a weariness beyond his years, together with a quiet form of self-doubt, as if he already considered his starting position to be structurally at a disadvantage.

Oak did not reply straight away. He simply looked at him, with a more attentive expression than before.

At that moment, Dr Fuji, who had been listening without intervening, gently set his cup down on the table. His hands were clasped in front of him, his fingers slightly clenched. He was not smiling. His gaze was fixed on Gold/Richter, but without insistence.

'I don't often interfere in areas for which I'm ill-qualified,' he said at last. 'Pure professional integrity.'

His voice was low, somewhat heavy.

BGM "EP07 S01 09:50 10:35"

He paused, then continued, in a slower tone:

'If my discourse on faith and science has indeed reached you… esoteric and alchemical teachings suggest: Fire, earth, water and wind are merely basic and superficial elements. The essence lies

within: ethics, integrity, faith… Science cannot replace these human values. It is neutral in itself. But detached from these guiding principles, it is science that takes hold of us. In that case, we justify ourselves by proving ourselves right… whilst being manipulated by it without our knowledge."

There was a kind of heavy, almost awkward melancholy in his voice. It wasn't a smooth speech. It was something rawer, more personal.

Gold/Richter looked at him without replying straight away.

Fuji lowered his gaze slightly towards his cup.

"Let's just say that… Oak and I share some similar regrets. But mine relate more to scientific ethics. They nearly became irreparable. To the point where I believe the same applies to combat. There's no point in underestimating you."

He looked up at Gold/Richter. His gaze was sincere, but awkward, as if he didn't quite know how to put what he meant into words.

"So, that is why even scientists must show humility in the face of tradition… All of this is what Red taught me." He paused for a moment, searching for the right words.

"Johto and Red… there's something they have in common, I think. A kind of restraint. A way of carrying what you've been given without turning it into a weapon. If I hadn't been told where he came from, I'd have thought Red was originally from Johto."

He looked at Gold/Richter, not quite into his eyes, but close enough for it to be noticeable.

"Since you've never met him, I hope his voice might reach you through me, in a certain context."

His sentence hung in the air, a little heavy, a little awkward, like an outstretched hand that wasn't quite sure it was welcome. He said nothing more.

Gold/Richter did not reply. He looked down at his cup again, his thumb resuming its slow back-and-forth movement along the rim of the porcelain.

Fuji said nothing more. He simply picked up his cup again, his hands trembling slightly.

The conversation ended there, naturally, without conclusion.
Oak finally raised his hand slightly to call the waiter. When he spoke, his voice had returned to its light, almost casual tone:

"The bill, please."

End of scene

Scene – Respecting Finitude

Near the Burned Tower

Twilight was already well advanced when Morty and Eusine settled down not far from the ruins of the Burned Tower. A few lanterns had been lit here and there, casting a low, warm light upon the blackened stones. A small group of villagers had gathered, mostly locals familiar with Eusine and his

tales. Among them, some were asking, with a curiosity that was both respectful and somewhat urgent, why Ho-Oh had chosen to resurrect the three beasts.

Eusine listened for a moment, then raised his hand slightly to quiet the voices.

‘Thank you for your trust,’ he said in a calm voice. ‘But tonight, I’d prefer to hand over to Morty. He’s better placed than I am to speak of what binds Ho-Oh to the three beasts… and what binds life to death.’

A brief silence fell. Eusine added, almost by way of explanation:

“Morty has always looked after this town as a Gym Leader. He deserves to answer your questions tonight.”

Morty nodded slowly. He seemed neither flattered nor embarrassed. He glanced round at the faces before him, then spoke in a deep, measured voice, without trying to capture their attention with any dramatic flourishes.

“I was expecting this question,” said Morty. “And the way it was phrased.”

He paused briefly, as if weighing his words.

“Many people regard Gym Leaders as nothing more than combat experts, or physical trainers. It’s a persistent notion. But it isn’t entirely accurate. Our responsibilities do not end with combat. They also include preserving and passing on what we have received.”

One of the listeners, a middle-aged man, interjected with a certain familiarity:

‘So… you’re not really into the supernatural, are you?’

Morty gave a faint, almost sad smile.

“I do not read tarot cards. I do not use Ouija boards. My clan is linked to the Spectre type, but not out of personal preference or mere family tradition. It is a way of serving Ho-Oh. Not by blindly obeying Him… but by understanding what He embodies.”

He lowered his gaze slightly towards the blackened stones at his feet.

“Ho-Oh embodies life and rebirth. But life cannot be understood without death. They are not opposites. They coexist. One gives meaning to the other. Without death, life would lose its significance. Without limits, there would be no sense of urgency, no gratitude, no true attachment. Eternity, as it is often imagined, is not a promise of joy. For many, it would become a burden.”

The audience had grown quieter. Morty continued, in a slightly lower voice:

“That is why we must receive the wisdom of those who have gone before us with humility and caution. Not because everything they have passed on is perfect. But because we are finite. Because we will die. And because this finitude compels us to choose what we pass on, and how.”

BGM “EP01 S02 19:53 20:33”

He looked up at the faces before him:

“That is why my family works with Ghost-type Pokémon. Not to dominate them. To better understand what lies on the other side, and to maintain a link between the living and those who are no longer

with us. Respect for death and the afterlife is not separate from respect for life. It is one and the same."

A heavier silence fell. Morty made no attempt to break it.

Chris/Maria, who was standing a little to one side with Gold/Richter, spoke up in a voice loud enough to be heard:

'…So why did Ho-Oh resurrect the three beasts, then?'

Morty turned his head slightly in their direction. He did not seem annoyed:

"Excellent question," he replied. "As far as I understand… Raikou, Entei and Suicune had left unfinished business before their deaths. Ho-Oh did not simply restore them to life out of mercy. He granted them the opportunity to finish what remained undone. In exchange, they swore allegiance to Him. Privilege, or rebirth, always carries a duty. Nothing is free."

Gold/Richter, who had been listening without speaking until then, murmured, almost to himself:

"Yes… They also bear the responsibilities of others. Even those who are simply clear-headed, without being exceptional."

Morty looked at him for a moment, then nodded slowly.

"That's right."

Behind Gold/Richter, a voice rang out, calm and somewhat distant:

"I was right to let him take the floor."

BGM 'She Who Mauls' 01:12–01:14

Gold/Richter turned round. Eusine had approached without him really noticing. Her expression was hard to read: neither hostile nor particularly warm. Just attentive.

"What?" asked Gold/Richter, somewhat surprised.

Eusine didn't reply straight away. He watched Gold/Richter for a moment, then said:

"Sorry for startling you. That wasn't my intention."

BGM "EP06 S01 10:00–10:37"

"...Good evening. As for my earlier questions… I didn't mean to challenge you, nor the tradition." Gold/Richter said, as if under threat.

"Do not blame yourself; the issue lies elsewhere," Eusine replied calmly.

Behind Gold/Richter, a voice rang out, calm and somewhat distant.

'Oh, so the question is whether Gold/Richter is an impostor?' said Chris/Maria.

Gold/Richter turned round, taken aback.

Chris/Maria had remained a little way back, her arms crossed. She hadn't raised her voice, but her expression was somewhat weary:

"Gold/Richter gets on better with older people than with his peers," she said. "That usually makes him… superior and bold. For better or for worse."

Gold/Richter shot her a sidelong glance, without any real anger.

“Didn’t you promise me you wouldn’t talk about my past?” he murmured.

Chris/Maria shrugged slightly.

“My promise was about what happened before your mission. Not after. So I’m in the clear.”

Eusine watched them for a moment without intervening. Then he turned his attention back to Gold/Richter, his gaze more direct.

“The question isn’t why you’re clever enough to ask these questions,” he said. “The question is: why do you need to ask them at your age?”

BGM ‘Making Monsters’ 00:50–

“I’m not trying to impress others. Nor to show off. It’s just that… I feel a bit out of step with my peers. So I try to adapt to the language of adults. Because I need a foothold somewhere else. That’s all.”

Eusine looked at him for a long time. His expression had softened slightly, though without becoming paternal. He nodded slowly.

“A young person striving to shine is often tinged with presumption. You, however, have almost none of that. That is rare. And it often means you have already paid a very heavy price for it.”

Gold/Richter did not deny it. He simply lowered his eyes again. After a moment, he replied in a more subdued voice:

“…Indeed. Not because I’m modest on principle. The price is so great that arrogance, vanity… cannot make up for what I’ve paid.”

Eusine continued, without trying to soften his words:

“Your questions were excellent. Most people — even those who are clear-headed — do not always know how to react to such weighty questions. It is not that they do not wish to help you. It is simply that they are unaccustomed to it, and it makes them feel uncomfortable. Discomfort makes people awkward. It’s not hostility. It’s just… human.”

Eusine was silent for a moment. Then he continued, in a calmer, almost measured voice:

“You’re seeking support from adults out of necessity. And you’re entitled to it. But you need to know that this sort of support takes time, and requires clearer ways of asking for it. Especially when you’re a Pokédex holder.”

Gold/Richter looked up, surprised.

“What? You already know that?”

Eusine raised an eyebrow slightly.

“If you were to take Professor Elm’s place as a young person… that was the only possibility.”

Another silence fell, this one even heavier. Eusine turned his head slightly towards the Burned Tower before continuing, in a lower voice:

“You should know that my nickname, ‘Suicune Hunter’, is now just a nickname. At first, it was a way of immersing myself in Johto’s culture. But as time went on… Suicune taught me something else. She

embodies a sense of responsibility. And through her, I've come to realise that tradition is fallible, but not in vain. You can still rely on it. Even if it does not shield you completely."

He stopped there. He made no attempt to add any gentler words of comfort. He simply looked at Gold/Richter for a moment longer, then turned his head slightly, as if he'd said all he needed to say.

Gold/Richter remained motionless. His shoulders were still slightly slumped, but something in his expression had changed — a sense of weariness that was a little less heavy, as if part of the burden had been acknowledged without being lifted.

Chris/Maria, standing beside him, said nothing. She simply stayed close, her gaze fixed on the floor.

End of scene

Scene – Falling in love with you again

Near the Tower of Tin (8 pm–10 pm)

The evening was already well underway. The lanterns, spaced further apart than at the start of the evening, cast a low, subdued light onto the cobblestones. The scent of traditional dishes had faded, and the conversations of the remaining festival-goers seemed more subdued, almost restrained. The atmosphere was no longer that of a party, but rather that of a gathering slowly drawing to a close.

Chris/Maria walked alongside Gold/Richter. Her pace was a little slower than usual, and her shoulders slumped slightly, as if the weight of the previous conversations had settled within her, unable to be shaken off. She wasn't complaining. She walked on, her arms crossed over her chest, her gaze somewhat lost as she looked straight ahead.

Gold/Richter glanced at her from time to time, though she didn't really notice. He had noticed the change in her breathing—it was heavier—and the way she sometimes clutched her arms more tightly against her body.

It was then that they spotted, almost at the same time, two figures in different places. On one side, near a stall selling votive lanterns, he made out Krise. The small figure in a short skirt and a jacket that was too big for her, with a red ribbon slightly askew in her hair. She was laughing softly with two other children her own age, yet her gaze kept returning to the crowd, as if she were looking for someone. On the other side, a little further away, Silver was standing in front of a stall selling local specialities. He was tasting the dishes in a restrained, almost studious manner, without any excessive indulgence.

Gold/Richter looked in both directions for a moment. Then he slowed to a halt. He placed a hand on Chris/Maria's arm, in a simple, almost instinctive gesture. When she turned slightly towards him, he was looking at her.

It was not a fleeting or embarrassed glance. He was truly looking at her. And in his eyes something from the past had resurfaced: an unvarnished tenderness, almost nostalgic, as if a part of him that he had long since set aside was reappearing in spite of himself. It was not a passionate or possessive look. It was something gentler, older, and a little sad. As if, for a moment, he'd forgotten to keep himself in check.

Chris/Maria was touched by it. A faint blush rose to her cheeks. She lowered her eyes, and her fingers clenched slightly against her arms. She sensed that this look was not calculated, that it was almost involuntary. And for that reason she could not bring herself to return it openly. She simply remained still, allowing the moment to exist without trying to prolong or break it.

Gold/Richter gently withdrew his hand. He glanced at Krise, then at Silver, before speaking in a low, almost neutral voice:

'Would you mind keeping Krise company? I'd prefer to look after Silver myself.'

Chris/Maria looked up, surprised.

"Are you going to handle him on your own? He's our age, after all…" she said.

Gold/Richter fell silent for a moment. His gaze had softened, and he made no attempt to hide it.

"You're more comfortable with this sort of thing than I am. But with a bloke like him… it's a bit tricky. And besides… you've looked after the others enough today. You've hardly had a moment to catch your breath."

BGM 'A Third Soul' 00:00 – 01:48

Chris/Maria faltered. She did not protest at once. She looked down at her own hands, then raised her eyes to him. In the dim light of the lanterns, her face had lost some of the tension she had been carrying for days.

Chris/Maria felt the heat rise to her cheeks. She lowered her head slightly, but not enough to hide the blush that had spread all the way to her ears. Gold/Richter was looking at her. Simply. Without teasing, without a smirk. Just a steady, attentive gaze, as if he were trying to make sure she was all right.

She said nothing. The sarcasm she usually resorted to in such moments remained stuck somewhere between her throat and her tongue. She did not want to let it out. Not just yet. Not now.

There was something very ancient stirring within her, something she'd thought she'd lost or damaged beyond repair. It hadn't returned intact. It was more fragile, more uncertain. She didn't know if it was something that had never completely disappeared, or if it was something new that was slowly taking shape again, something she couldn't quite trust yet.

She kept her eyes down for a moment longer, just long enough for the flush to subside a little. When she looked up again, her expression had returned to being almost neutral. Almost.

She did not move straight away. Her eyelids drooped for a moment, as if she needed to check that this contact was real. When she opened her eyes again, they were a little brighter, but she did not cry. She turned her head slightly, just enough for her cheeks to almost brush against Gold/Richter's fingers. A tiny gesture. Almost nothing. But he felt it.

He did not withdraw his hand straight away. He let the silence stretch out between them, for the duration of a heartbeat, then two. All around them, the lanterns swayed gently in the night breeze. In the distance, the ritual bells of the Tin Tower could be heard, and closer by, the murmur of an old woman explaining to a child why they weren't dancing this year as they had before.

Chris/Maria finally spoke, her voice low, almost hoarse:

'I'm going to miss you, even though you're right here. See you later.'

She turned away and walked off in the direction of Krise. Gold/Richter stood motionless for a moment, his eyes fixed on her receding figure. He made no move to catch up with her or to say anything else. He simply watched her until she was swallowed up by the last groups of festival-goers.

Then he turned in the other direction.

Silver had noticed him approaching and paused in his tasting. He looked up at him with a wry half-smile.

“Hello there, Mr Prison Officer.”

There was still a hint of causticity in his voice, but it wasn’t really aggressive. More defensive.

Gold/Richter stopped a few paces away from him.

“That label isn’t meant for me.”

Silver raised an eyebrow slightly.

“Am I not under your supervision? What do you think of my performance?”

Gold/Richter regarded him for a moment before replying, in a calm voice:

“It’s just a festival.”

Silver took another bite, slowly, before speaking again.

“If you’re proud of your tradition… shouldn’t you be pleased that outsiders are taking such an interest in it?”

He did not specify that ‘outsiders’ included himself. Gold/Richter did not take the bait.

“Certainly. But if the tradition boils down to gastronomy… it’s a bit superficial.”

Silver looked at him, a wry half-smile playing on his lips.

“Oh. So gastronomy isn’t part of the tradition…?”

Gold/Richter remained silent for a moment. He knew that Silver was not really trying to hurt him, but rather to preserve some of his pride, albeit in a slightly awkward way. He replied without harshness:

“Yes. But traditional tasting alone isn’t really enough to understand the culture.”

Silver did not reply straight away. He looked down at what he was still holding in his hand, as if weighing up his response.

Gold/Richter, for his part, looked away slightly towards the spot where Chris/Maria had disappeared. He murmured, more to himself than to Silver:

“Sometimes I wonder if I’m a warden… a prison officer… or some sort of guardian.”

He didn’t elaborate. He simply stood there, beside Silver, in the silence that had once again settled between them.

End of scene

Scene – Hoothoot's aerial observation

The night was deep and moonless over Ecruteak. On the sloping roof of an old house, Bird Keeper Bryan remained crouched, perfectly still. Beside him, Hoothoot patrolled the sky at an altitude barely perceptible to humans. Its large, silent wings cut through the black air with an almost mechanical regularity.

Below, the festival went on quietly. The low-hanging lanterns swayed gently in the breeze. Voices were hushed. Nothing seemed likely to disturb this tranquillity.

Hoothoot suddenly came to a halt in mid-air.

BGM: 'She Who Mauls' (02:41–02:48)

His round eyes fixed on a specific point, amongst the dark branches of a large oak tree. He remained frozen, as if suspended.

Then, in the deepest shadow, two red dots appeared.

BGM: 'EP04 S02 14:40–15:00'

They did not blink. They opened all at once, as if something had been waiting for precisely that glance to reveal itself. The eyes were hollow, almost glassy, and yet they seemed moist, as if covered by a thin film that caught the faint light of the lanterns. A very ancient chill seemed to emanate from them. Hoothoot shuddered violently. A strangled cry escaped from its beak, so high-pitched that it was almost inaudible.

Bryan sat up slightly.

Without haste, the two red dots began to move. Murkrow emerged from the shadows with deliberate slowness. Its wings spread in a wide, sweeping arc, almost calligraphic, like a vulture with all the time in the world. There was nothing abrupt about the movement. It was slow, ponderous, almost ritualistic, as if the air itself had to yield ground. The rustling of its feathers was barely audible. Only a very slight draught of air, colder than the rest of the night, drifted down to the ground.

Hoothoot did not wait.

He spun round abruptly and fled.

He streaked across the sky above the square at full speed, so low that one might have thought he was grazing the lanterns. Below, Mini Skirt Krise looked up for a fraction of a second, as if a cold draught had brushed the nape of her neck. Chris/Maria, who was speaking softly to her, frowned slightly without knowing why. Gold/Richter, a few paces away, merely felt a draught of air colder than the rest of the night. None of them looked up. None of them realised what had just happened.

Hoothoot did not stop until he reached Bryan. He landed abruptly on the gutter, feathers ruffled, eyes bulging. He was shaking violently. A small, strangled cry, almost inaudible, escaped from his beak.

Bryan did not speak.

He watched his Pokémon for a long moment. His jaw tightened imperceptibly. His breathing, which had been calm until then, slowed even further. He slowly turned his head towards the spot where the two red dots had vanished. The shadow of the oak tree had returned to normal. Nothing was moving anymore.

Yet he remained motionless, his eyes fixed on the darkness, as if he expected the red eyes to reappear at any moment. He did not move. He did not send out his Pokémon. He made no gesture towards the crowd below.

He knew a sign when he saw one.

And this one boded nothing good.

Below, the festival carried on quietly, as if nothing had happened.

End of scene

Scene – The girls' outpouring

Foyer. Ecruteak

Night had long since fallen over Ecruteak. The low lanterns, veiled in ochre and grey paper, cast a light upon the cobblestones that already seemed weary of itself. The air was cool, heavy with the scent of fallen leaves and cold ash. The voices around the square remained low, almost reverent. No one laughed aloud; the Ash Vigil festival was no time for mirth.

Chris/Maria and Mini Skirt Krise strolled side by side at a leisurely pace, almost like a Jigglypuff indulging in a slow stroll. Krise had noticed Chris/Maria's weariness for some time now. She hadn't said anything straight away. But after a while, she turned her head slightly.

Krise looked at her out of the corner of her eye.

'You look exhausted. Are you all right?'

Chris/Maria let out a small sigh.

"It's because of Gold/Richter. It's exhausting keeping up with him without getting overwhelmed… I can't even imagine any other girl agreeing to go with him on this sort of thing."

Krise raised her eyebrows slightly.

"He's rather… attractive, isn't he?"

Chris/Maria turned her head towards her, a little surprised.

"Attractive? No, not really. He's put on some muscle, that's for sure, and he dresses differently now. His face is still sharp. But… a handsome lad? I don't know. He's rather ordinary, physically speaking."

Krise tilted her head slightly, thinking.

"But there is something endearing about him, all the same. Just like Red before him."

Chris/Maria let out a small, dry laugh.

"Cute? He's not an innocent child any more."

"No, I mean…" replied Krise slowly. "Being cute isn't just about someone being clueless and naive. With Gold/Richter, it's something else. It's a kindness that's been… honed. After everything he's been through. He just wants to protect the people who matter to him."

Chris/Maria walked a few paces without replying. She lowered her eyes slightly.

“You care about him, don’t you?”

Krise shook her head gently.

“No. I don’t think it would be right. Even though… I admit he has something about him. But my gut tells me he already loves someone. He really does. So I don’t think it would be right to become attached like that, without any consideration.”

Chris/Maria fell silent for a moment. When she spoke, her voice was softer.

“Yes… The one who truly loves him realised it too late. He’s already left her with scars. Deep ones. Even though he didn’t mean to. Even though he thought he was protecting her.”

The BGM ‘Sunrise, Sunset’ began to play softly.

Krise said nothing straight away. She watched Chris/Maria: the way her fingers clenched the fabric of her sleeve, her gaze shifting away for a moment. She understood without needing it explained to her.

‘I see,’ she murmured. ‘Things between the two of you are more complicated than you let on.’

Chris/Maria felt the heat rise to her cheeks. She lowered her head too quickly and raised a hand to her face, as if to hide what could no longer be hidden.

“Sorry… We didn’t want the others to know. Not to lie to you, mind you. But… he’s afraid it might be used against us. By those who’d want to hurt us.”

Krise shook her head gently.

“It’s all right… We all have things we keep to ourselves. Even with those closest to us. Otherwise… friendship becomes too easy, or too burdensome, I don’t know. Trust… that’s something you build, isn’t it? You can’t force it by demanding that everything be said. I’d rather you told me things because you want to. Not because you feel obliged to.”

They walked on in silence for a while longer. Ahead of them, Juggler Mike had begun his performance.

He was not speaking. He was spinning three empty Poké Balls between his hands, with a fluid and very precise movement. It was not clear whether it was acrobatics or sleight of hand. The trajectories were sometimes too slow, sometimes too sharp. One ball vanished between his fingers and reappeared further away, without anyone being able to quite see how. Mike kept a focused, almost neutral expression, as if he were simply doing his job.

A few people had stopped to watch. Not many. They watched with quiet attention. No one clapped. When he put his balls away in his bag, the onlookers dispersed gently, without a sound.

The background music remained unobtrusive throughout the performance.

Chris/Maria watched Mike walk away, then turned her head slightly towards Krise.

“Say… do you always pull that innocent face to hide the fact that you understand more than you let on? It’s a bit sneaky, isn’t it?”

Krise shrugged, taking no offence.

“Not really. I’m not very good with complicated things. If I don’t pull that face, I panic. It’s my way of staying calm. Mike, on the other hand, is more at ease with people. But he finds it hard to see what’s really going on inside others… Boys are often like that. They’re slow to understand. And when they do understand, they sometimes overreact.”

Chris/Maria let out a little sigh, somewhere between a laugh and exhaustion.

“Gold/Richter is the perfect example. As soon as he understands something profound… he goes too far. Always.”

Krise smiled slightly.

“Yes…”

They stood for a moment, looking at the spot where Mike had been playing. The applause had been subdued, almost reserved.

It was then that they saw Bird Keeper Bryan emerge from the crowd. He looked dejected. Perched on his hand was Hoothoot, its feathers ruffled, clearly panicked. The Pokémon refused to fly away. Jigglypuff, who was walking a little ahead, stopped dead in its tracks, ears pricked up, unsettled by the fear emanating from Hoothoot.

Krise took a step towards Bryan.

“Bryan? What’s going on?”

Bryan looked at Hoothoot, then turned his gaze towards the dark rooftops.

“Something… something’s afoot. I don’t know what. But Hoothoot’s sensed it.”

Hoothoot was still trembling. The panic seemed to have spread to Jigglypuff, who had crept up to Krise without a sound. None of them really understood what was happening. All they knew was that they felt uneasy.

End of scene

Scene – Art is not neutral

Near the Tin Tower, Ecruteak City (9.00–10.00 pm, autumn)

The Kimono Girls’ dance had already been going on for some time when Gold/Richter approached. He had been watching for a while, standing slightly to one side, his hands in his coat pockets. The air was cool, heavy with the scent of fallen leaves and cold ash. The low-hanging lanterns cast a warm, subdued light upon the damp cobblestones.

One of the dancers, standing slightly apart, was not fully taking part. She stood there, her fan closed against her thigh, her gaze fixed on her sisters. Gold/Richter recognised her vaguely: she was the one he had already come across earlier that evening. He approached without really thinking, his gait a little awkward.

‘Your sisters would envy you this privilege… of being able to enjoy the show without having to dance, wouldn’t they…?’

Kuni turned her head slightly towards him. She didn't seem surprised, but her gaze was weary.

"How so? I'm not in any state to dance today. Or perhaps it's just as well that I'm talking rather than dancing right now."

She had spoken in a calm, almost neutral voice. There was no sarcasm, just a kind of weary clarity.

Gold/Richter fell silent for a moment. He watched the dance without really seeing it.

"To be honest… I still know very little about you. To me, the Kimono Girls were mostly a legend. Someone who left their hometown not long ago… it all feels rather abstract."

Kuni looked at him for a moment. When she spoke, her voice was a little lower, almost as if she were responding to something else.

"Thank you. But we don't know so little about you."

Gold/Richter felt a faint warmth rise to his cheeks. He lowered his eyes slightly. He thought of Naoko, the girl he'd bumped into earlier, and wondered what she might have said. He wasn't ashamed of having taken on Team Rocket, but he didn't like the idea of it becoming a story that got around.

"I'm sorry… if I seemed to be defying tradition just now. For a teenager, I'm actually quite traditional. I was even… blindly religious at one time. Almost obsessive, according to some."

Kuni did not reply straight away.

She turned her attention back to the dance. The fans opened and closed in a slow, almost hypnotic rhythm. The dark fabrics brushed the floor with a very soft rustle. Something in the atmosphere had changed: the movements seemed a little heavier, as if the dancers were carrying something invisible.

A silence settled between them. Neither of them seemed in any hurry to break it.

Gold/Richter finally spoke, in a slightly lower voice, almost to himself:

'…I'm feeling something strange. Like a sense of serenity I used to know… but at the same time, there's a weight to it. Is it the art that's doing this? Because art is neutral… isn't it?'

Kuni kept her eyes on the dance for a moment.

"Professor Oak says that science is neutral in itself. But art… art isn't really."

BGM 'Being Dracula's Son'

Gold/Richter turned his head towards her, surprised.

"What do you mean?"

"Because you get the impression that it doesn't take sides. But that's not entirely true. Ever since we created art, it has already absorbed our thoughts, our breath, our way of seeing things. It doesn't remain neutral for very long."

She paused. Her voice remained calm, almost gentle.

"Johto is rich in its heritage. But its values are simple… and sometimes difficult to pass on. The dignity of life. Respect for life and death. Harmony with nature and Pokémon. Nothing grandiose. But all of this requires a great deal of care to endure."

Gold/Richter fell silent. He watched the dance once more. The movements had become slower, more introspective. The fans were no longer merely tracing lines: they seemed to be holding something in the air, as if preventing it from dispersing too quickly.

He finally asked, in a slightly hesitant voice:

“So… why is it so… melancholic?”

Kuni did not take her eyes off the dance.

“It’s not always like this. But in recent years… a lot has happened. We weren’t properly prepared. And when you don’t know how to protect what matters, art sometimes becomes the only way to express what you can’t put into words any other way.”

She turned her head slightly towards him, for the first time in a while.

“Your questions to Eusine weren’t offensive. But few people have had the courage to ask them. Even though they were important questions.”

Kuni kept her eyes on the dance. Her voice was low, almost as if she were speaking to herself.

“…Sometimes, dance says what we cannot put into words any other way. It doesn’t force anything. We just have to watch it. Really watch it.”

She remained silent for a moment without adding anything. The dance continued, slower, heavier. Gold/Richter no longer felt like asking questions. He contented himself with watching, with a slightly different focus from before — as if he were beginning to sense, without yet understanding it, that there was a gap between what he carried and what the Kimono Girls still carried.

Gold/Richter said nothing. He sensed that something had shifted within him, though he could not yet put his finger on it. The dance continued, slower, heavier, and he had the impression that it spoke of something other than what he could see.

End of scene

Scene – Strong Pokémon. Weak Pokémon

The Kimono Girls’ dance continued, a little slower and more introspective than at the start. The movements had lost some of their sharpness. The fans opened with less vigour, and the dark fabrics seemed heavier with every rotation. The air around the circle seemed denser.

Karin had approached silently. She stopped beside Kuni and bowed slightly.

‘It’s been ages, Miss Kuni?’

Kuni turned her head towards her. A small, weary but sincere smile appeared on her face.

“Miss Karin. Yes… it’s been a long time.”

Gold/Richter had recognised her voice. He remembered her from the conference in Eusine. He hadn’t taken any particular interest in her at the time, but now that she was there, he could no longer quite pretend she didn’t exist.

He looked at her for a moment, then asked politely, though with a certain reserve:

‘Can you tell which one it is? Are you that close?’

Karin glanced briefly at him.

“Close enough to recognise each other. We’re old acquaintances. Did you enjoy the performance?”

Karin turned her attention back to the dance before replying.

“Certainly. More so than before. It’s… rather phenomenal tonight. I hope it’s just my imagination.”

She had said this in a calm voice, but Gold/Richter noticed that she had briefly looked away towards the darkness beyond the lanterns. It wasn’t a worried look, just an attentive one. He didn’t press the matter.

He hesitated for a moment, then asked gently:

“Am I to assume that you remember my cheeky questions more than you do my existence…?”

Karin looked at him frankly this time.

“Not quite. But rather because my presence doesn’t surprise you… despite your connection to Professor Oak.”

Gold/Richter fell silent for a few seconds. He suddenly recalled how Oak had behaved earlier that evening. He finally said, in a slightly lower voice:

“…In the end, I understood. The professor tried not to draw attention to me. And he did the same with you. That was it, wasn’t it? How is it that I should have any preconceptions…?”

Karin shrugged slightly, without a trace of irony.

“Given that we’re exposed to appearances and gossip…”

Gold/Richter lowered his eyes slightly.

“Do not trouble yourself. I would not wish to know, in truth. We all have our limits, myself included. There have been too many events over the past two years for me to keep track of everything, even when it comes to someone as prominent as you.”

Karin looked at him for a moment, as if weighing up her reply. Then she spoke in a slightly softer voice:

“He often describes me as unusual, or too philosophical. I still feel rather uncomfortable when it comes to claiming a status that is neutral in itself. I probably wouldn’t have found my place without people like the professor. That said… it’s quite rare to see someone in your circle, at your age, in so little hurry to move forward. May I ask why?”

Gold/Richter did not reply straight away. He was watching the dance without really seeing it. When he spoke, his voice was calm:

“My journey began because the Professor asked me to gather data on Pokémon and battles. Taking on Gyms was part of that, but nothing more than that. I’m sticking to travelling around Johto for the time being. Let’s just say… I’m trying to learn the essence of our culture before going any further.”

Karin nodded slightly.

“I see.”

Gold/Richter turned his head slightly towards her.

“And you, what brings you here? If it isn’t for scientific reasons. Not out of prejudice, just out of curiosity.”

Karin kept her eyes on the dance for a moment. Then she replied, in a lower voice:

“Let us simply say that the professor’s motives are not confined to science. In a sense, we all spring from the same source. And unlike him, I hail from Johto. That, I believe, is a valid reason.”

She bowed slightly towards Kuni.

“Miss Kuni… You serve Ho-oh and Lugia. But you are not their voice. They are with us, it is true. Yet they do not wish for us to worship them blindly. They would rather we forged our own path.”

Kuni nodded, unsurprised.

“Indeed.”

BGM: *‘Part of the Same* History’

Karin remained silent for a moment. When she spoke again, her voice was softer, almost as if she were speaking to herself:

“That is what makes Johto unique. They do not expect worship, but rather that goodness lies dormant within almost everyone. That is what makes life so… changeable, and sometimes so difficult to preserve.”

The dance was drawing to a close. The movements had become very slow, almost solemn. The fans opened and closed with visible restraint.

Karin turned her head slightly towards Gold/Richter. She wore a faint, wry smile, not quite amused.

Karin let her gaze return to the dance for a moment, then added in a slightly lower voice, almost as if quoting something ancient:

‘Strong Pokémon. Weak Pokémon. That is only the selfish perception of people. Truly skilled trainers should try to win with their favorites.’

Gold/Richter remained silent for a few seconds. He did not attempt to reply at once. When he spoke, his voice was cautious, almost hesitant:

“…That idea… it reduces Pokémon to what they can contribute in battle, doesn’t it? As if they were only valuable for their strength, their weakness or their cunning. Is that really the only way to look at them?”

Karin looked at him for a moment. Her smile widened slightly, without a trace of calculation.

“This is the first time anyone has questioned that adage so directly. And so promptly, too.”

Gold/Richter looked away slightly, feeling a little uncomfortable. He wasn’t used to people noticing so clearly how he was thinking.

Karin continued, in a slightly lower voice:

“It may have been my idea to begin with. But I think it stems from a time when we still needed simple formulas. These days… things are a bit more complicated. I’ve come to realise that knowing whether a Pokémon is strong or weak isn’t just about battle. It’s also about respect for life. Every living thing contributes to the world’s evolution, even in its own way. Even those who never win a battle.”

She paused, then added more softly:

“Simple values are precious, but they’re fragile. They need to be upheld in ways other than just words. That’s why we dance. And that’s why some of us have sought other ways to bring them to life.”

Kuni, who had been listening without interrupting, lowered her eyes slightly. She said nothing, but her expression had darkened.

Karin continued, in an almost calm voice:

“The professor and I come from different backgrounds. But we’ve both felt the need for certain things to remain alive, even when they change form. Art is one of them.”

The dance was drawing to a close. The movements had become very slow, almost solemn. The fans opened and closed with visible restraint. The atmosphere around the circle had become heavier, more contemplative.

BGM ‘EP05 S02 18:21–18:59’

Karin did not move straight away. Her gaze, which had been fixed on the dance, shifted slightly. It was not a sudden movement. Just a discreet glancing of her eyes towards the darkness beyond the lanterns. Something in her expression had changed—barely perceptible. Her face remained calm, but her gaze had become a little more fixed, a little more attentive, as if she were seeking to confirm something she had already sensed.

Gold/Richter, who was watching her without really meaning to, noticed this slight change. He didn’t immediately understand what was happening. He simply sensed that the quality of the air around them had imperceptibly shifted. As if something, somewhere, had begun to weigh a little more heavily.

Karin remained silent for a moment longer. Then she spoke again, in a lower voice, almost as if she were talking to herself:

‘…Even so, something is happening.’

She had not raised her voice. Her expression had not changed dramatically. But something in her voice had lost some of its previous gentleness. Her gaze remained fixed on the darkness, watchful, almost predatory, though she made no attempt to alarm anyone.

Gold/Richter felt a slight tension build in the nape of his neck. He did not yet know why.

End of scene

Final scene – The appearance of the Night Creatures

BGM: *'Don't Listen to Her'* (01:04 → 02:04)

Night had fallen thickly over Ecruteak. The festival lanterns were still burning, but their light struggled to pierce the darkness that had settled between the buildings. The air had grown colder, more damp.

Then the sounds began.

They burst forth without warning: a sudden, membranous flapping of vast wings, a sharp, repeated click of a forked tongue, high-pitched squeaks mingled with the sound of teeth clacking forcefully. These noises were not distant. They came from the dark areas, right on the edge of the festival.

Gold/Richter froze. He had recognised something in those sounds. It wasn't the chaotic savagery of an ordinary wild Pokémon. It was heavier, more ancient. He suddenly remembered the battle against Lance at the well. He had prepared himself to face something structured, something controlled. These sounds were different.

All around him, the first screams rang out.

Festival-goers began to flee. Some ran aimlessly; others remained frozen in place, too terrified to react. A woman stumbled and fell, then scrambled to her feet, screaming without even looking behind her. The festival's solemn atmosphere was shattered in an instant.

Gold/Richter moved closer to the source of the sounds, his body tense. He emerged from between two buildings and saw them.

They were emerging from the shadows.

A massive Raticate led the way, its prominent teeth glinting in the dim light. It wasn't running. It walked with deliberate heaviness, its tail dragging behind it and scraping against the stone. Its eyes were fixed, almost glassy. It was nibbling at the air in short, jerky bursts, as if searching for something to bite.

Behind it, an Arbok slowly uncoiled from a patch of shadow. Its thick body scraped against the ground with a dull, continuous sound. It did not hiss. It merely raised its head at regular intervals, its forked tongue extending and retracting in an almost hypnotic rhythm. Its vividly patterned scales seemed to absorb the light rather than reflect it.

Above them, a Golbat let itself drop from a ledge. Its wings spread in a sweeping, silent motion before closing partially. It landed on a low wall, its claws dug into the stone. A low, unpleasant rumbling emanated from its throat, faint at first, but already audible.

All around them, other, smaller figures appeared: nervous Rattata running in irregular circles, Zubat clustering beneath the eaves, and a Koffing hovering low, its gas escaping in irregular bursts.

They had no Trainer.

Gold/Richter realised this almost immediately. There was no one to command them. No henchman, no executive. These Pokémon were acting on their own, and yet they did not scatter into chaos. They moved forward with a kind of primitive, almost ritualistic coordination. The smaller ones seemed to

gravitate towards the three largest, as if they were following something they themselves did not understand.

He drew his leveller with a swift movement and checked it.

The shock was greater than he'd anticipated.

Level 22. Perhaps 23 for the Arbok. The others were even lower. This was not what he had prepared for. He had anticipated powerful, well-trained Pokémon—perhaps even over-trained ones. Not this. Not creatures of relatively modest level, yet exuding such intense savagery—so… false.

He remembered the Arbok he had seen on television, at the end of episode 03, in Goldenrod, in front of the shop window. The same feeling came over him: a visceral, almost animalistic terror that had nothing strategic about it. Just an evil, patient, and hungry presence.

He forced himself to breathe more slowly.

He threw two Poké Balls.

Fearow appeared with a powerful flap of its wings. Alakazam materialised at its side, spoons already raised. Gold/Richter drew his hunting crop from his belt and adjusted it in his right hand, the leather creaking softly against his glove.

He did not name the creatures. He did not need to.

The Raticate turned its head towards him. Its black eyes stared at him without blinking. The Arbok froze, its tongue slowly protruding between its fangs. The Golbat raised its head, and its buzzing intensified a notch.

They did not seem surprised to see him.

They looked as though they'd been expecting him.

Gold/Richter gripped his hunting crop tighter. Fear was there, cold and heavy in his chest, but he kept it at bay. He'd seen this sort of savagery once before. He knew he couldn't afford to stand frozen.

BGM 'Powerful Predatory Deadly' 02:14–02:18

The Golbat's roar grew even louder.

All around them, the lanterns continued to burn, but their light seemed to have lost all its warmth.

End of episode

Close of episode

Totals

Scenes: 11 · Words: ≈ 15,200 · Read aloud: ≈ 100 min · 34 pp. A4.

Pass 1/3 — still open

Scene titles. niveleur (not leveller). Silent Karin. tongue protruded. to be heard. metalepsis ep. 03. Little Boy Belmont without span. History / story. Eusine gender in the EN body. crop ≠ whip. Kuni / Krise pronouns.

Version notes

2026-09-23 — EN-GB apparatus after P1. Traces = EP S span only. No christening. EN anchors. Author filled. Cover / sheet / close translated from the FR dossier; scene titles frozen as below.

Open for what follows

Masterless creatures · Hoothoot · cry beyond the hall · Silver mentioned to Krise.

BGM credits

Pieces: Castlevania: Nocturne (Netflix), Trevor Morris & Trey Toy. Traces: same sources, identified by duration in the series, untitled.